

Supplementary file

Figures

Figure S1. Invitation email for the control condition

Hi there,

Thank you for signing up for our study earlier! We hope you will participate in the survey about your mental health status during the pandemic.

- It takes 15 minutes.
- You will be asked to answer some demographic questions and the main questionnaire includes 8 closed-ended (Scale Multiple Choice Questions).
- For your time, we will email you two £1 UK Amazon e-vouchers.

[Take the Survey](#)

Please complete the survey by Monday, August 15th.

About this survey: Your answers will remain anonymous and will be used by the researcher's graduation thesis. I hope you'll take 15 minutes to complete the survey and enjoy your gift!

Figure S2. Invitation email for the decoy condition (target shown first)

Hi there,
Thank you for signing up for our study earlier! We hope you will participate in the survey about your mental health status during the pandemic.

The survey may take you 15 minutes and there are two types of questionnaires **you can choose.**

	Closed-ended questions	Open-ended questions
Question Type	Eight scale multiple choice questions	Two open-ended questions (answer each question with no less than 100 words)
Reward	£2 UK Amazon e-vouchers	£2 UK Amazon e-vouchers
Date of Receiving your Reward	1 week after you finish the survey	4 weeks after you finish the survey (as we need to check your answer)
Link to the survey	https://wbs.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_eaFc89M5mDDMYBM	https://wbs.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_098JKc7HG60MNng

Please complete **one questionnaire** by 8 PM (UK Time), Tuesday, August 16th.

About this survey: Your answers will remain anonymous and will be used in the researcher's graduation thesis. I hope you'll take 15 minutes to complete the survey and enjoy your gift!

Figure S3. Invitation email for the decoy condition (decoy shown first)

Hi there,

Thank you for signing up for our study earlier! We hope you will participate in the survey about your mental health status during the pandemic.

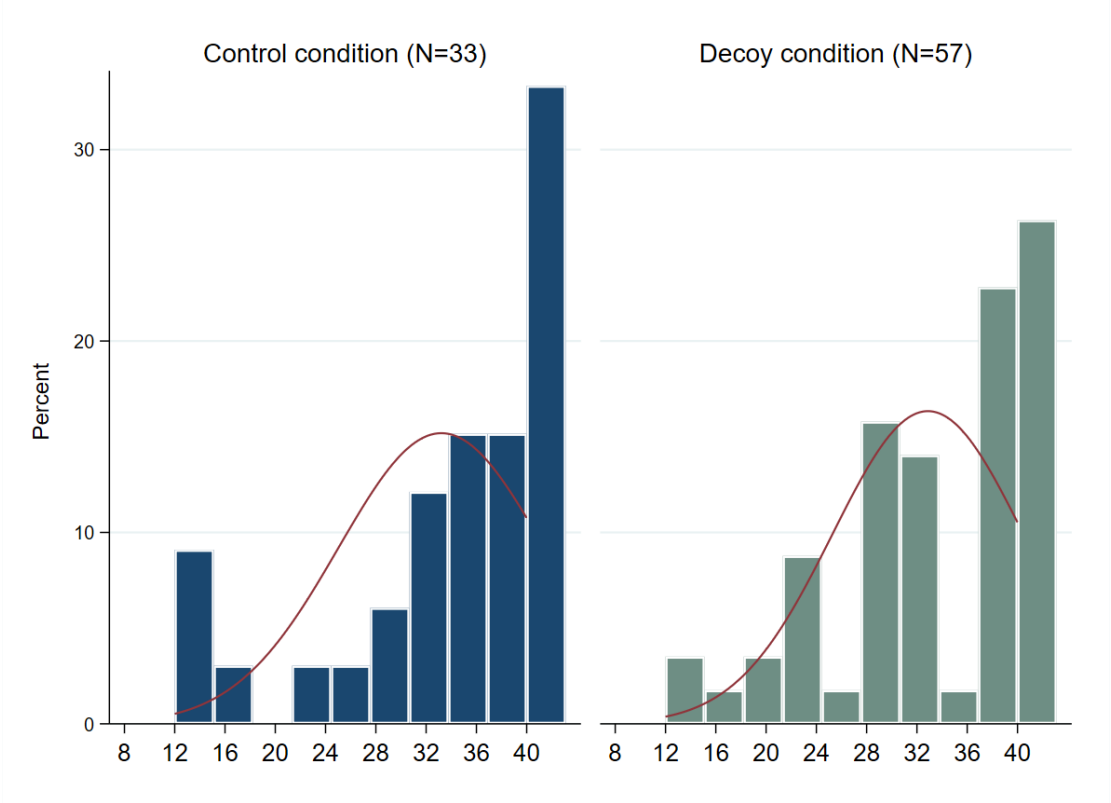
The survey may take you 15 minutes and there are two types of questionnaires **you can choose.**

	Open-ended questions	Closed-ended questions
Question Type	Two open-ended questions (answer each question with no less than 100 words)	Eight scale multiple choice questions
Reward	£2 UK Amazon e-vouchers	£2 UK Amazon e-vouchers
Date of Receiving your Reward	4 weeks after you finish the survey (as we need to check your answer)	1 week after you finish the survey
Link to the survey	https://wbs.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_bvVIQ1wA3OCjTNA	https://wbs.qualtrics.com/jfe/form/SV_5AVtjnKzjfPiWq

Please complete **one questionnaire** by 8 PM (UK Time), Tuesday, August 16th.

About this survey: Your answers will remain anonymous and will be used in the researcher's graduation thesis. I hope you'll take 15 minutes to complete the survey and enjoy your gift!

Figure S4. Distribution of FCQ scores across the two experimental conditions (N=90)



Tables

Table S1. Key features of the questionnaires

	Target questionnaire (control condition)	Target questionnaire (decoy condition)	Decoy questionnaire (decoy condition)
Payment			
Amazon voucher	£2 after 1 week	£2 after 1 week	£2 after 4 weeks
Questions			
Socio-demographic questions	Age, gender, ethnicity, religion and education	Age, gender, ethnicity, religion and education	Age, gender, ethnicity, religion and education
Fear of coronavirus	8 close-ended questions from FCQ	8 close-ended questions from FCQ	2 open-ended questions
Debrief questions	None	Reasons for choice and stimulated by decoy option	Reasons for choice and stimulated by decoy option

Table S2. Description of the study sample for the preliminary questionnaire (N=210)

	N	(%)
Age		
20-24	56	(26.7)
25-29	107	(50.9)
30-35	47	(22.4)
Gender		
Male	110	(52.4)
Female	100	(47.6)
Ethnicity		
White	120	(57.1)
Asian	50	(23.8)
Black	36	(17.1)
Other	4	(1.9)
Religion		
Christian	151	(71.9)
Other religion	41	(19.5)
No Religion	18	(8.6)
Education Level		
Bachelor's Degree	109	(51.9)
Graduate or professional degree	101	(48.1)

Table S3. Binary logistic regression on completing the target survey (N=203)

	(%)	Unadjusted model		Adjusted model	
		OR	95% CI	aOR	95% CI
Overall	(44.3)				
Condition					
Control	(32.7)	Ref.		Ref.	
Decoy	(59.8)	2.610	1.475 – 4.618**	2.584	1.415 – 4.718**
Age					
20-24	(45.5)	Ref.		Ref.	
25-29	(46.1)	1.025	0.531 – 1.981	1.016	0.465 - 2.221
30-35	(39.1)	0.771	0.348 – 1.709	0.764	0.264 - 2.210
Gender					
Male	(44.3)	Ref.		Ref.	
Female	(44.3)	1.000	0.574 – 1.740	0.966	0.521 - 1.791
Ethnicity					
White	(44.4)	Ref.		Ref.	
Asian	(50.0)	1.250	0.638 – 2.450	1.261	0.589 - 2.700
Black	(38.2)	0.774	0.354 – 1.691	0.821	0.313 - 2.154
Other	(25.0)	0.417	0.042 – 4.124	0.519	0.047 - 5.693
Religion					
Christian	(43.2)	Ref.		Ref.	
Other religion	(55.6)	1.647	0.615 – 4.413	2.111	0.714 – 6.241
No religion	(43.6)	1.018	0.499 – 2.076	1.435	0.572 - 3.601
Education					
Bachelor	(48.6)	Ref.		Ref.	
Graduate	(39.8)	0.700	0.401 – 1.221	0.769	0.399 - 1.481
<i>N</i>		203		203	

* $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$

Table S4. Binary logistic regression on completing the target survey looking at the order of the presentation (N=203)

	(%)	Unadjusted model		Adjusted model	
		OR	95% CI	aOR	95% CI
Overall	(44.3)				
Condition					
Control	(32.7)	Ref.		Ref.	
Decoy – Target first	(82.7)	9.845	4.293 – 22.580**	11.177	4.571 – 27.330**
Decoy – Decoy first	(28.0)	0.801	0.381 – 1.687	0.746	0.341 – 1.631
Age					
20-24	(45.5)	Ref.		Ref.	
25-29	(46.1)	1.025	0.531 – 1.981	1.023	0.436 – 2.401
30-35	(39.1)	0.771	0.348 – 1.709	1.498	0.478 – 4.691
Gender					
Male	(44.3)	Ref.		Ref.	
Female	(44.3)	1.000	0.574 – 1.740	0.830	0.421 – 1.638
Ethnicity					
White	(44.4)	Ref.		Ref.	
Asian	(50.0)	1.250	0.638 – 2.450	1.818	0.788 – 4.195
Black	(38.2)	0.774	0.354 – 1.691	0.988	0.344 - 2.834
Other	(25.0)	0.417	0.042 – 4.124	0.381	0.026 - 5.490
Religion					
Christian	(43.2)	Ref.		Ref.	
Other religion	(55.6)	1.647	0.615 – 4.413	0.971	0.284 – 3.325
No religion	(43.6)	1.018	0.499 – 2.076	1.296	0.465 – 3.614
Education					
Bachelor	(48.6)	Ref.		Ref.	
Graduate	(45.5)	0.700	0.401 – 1.221	0.816	0.396 – 1.679
<i>N</i>		203		203	

p<0.05; ** *p*<0.01

Table S5. Characteristics of individuals choosing the target survey (N=90)

	Control condition (N=33)		Decoy condition (N=57)		p-value*	Total (N=90)	
	N	(%)	N	(%)		N	(%)
Age							
20-24	13	(39.4)	12	(21.1)	0.122	25	(27.8)
25-29	13	(39.4)	34	(57.6)		47	(52.2)
30-35	7	(21.2)	11	(19.3)		18	(20.0)
Gender							
Male	16	(48.5)	31	(54.4)	0.589	47	(52.2)
Female	17	(51.5)	26	(45.6)		43	(47.8)
Ethnicity							
White	12	(36.4)	40	(70.2)	0.006 ⁺	52	(57.8)
Asian	14	(42.4)	10	(17.5)		24	(26.7)
Black	7	(21.2)	6	(10.5)		13	(14.4)
Other	0	(0.0)	1	(1.8)		1	(1.1)
Religion							
Christian	20	(60.6)	43	(75.4)	0.329	63	(70.0)
Non-Christian	5	(15.2)	5	(8.8)		10	(11.1)
No religion	8	(24.2)	9	(15.8)		17	(18.9)
Education							
Bachelor	21	(63.6)	30	(52.6)	0.310	51	(56.7)
Graduate	12	(36.4)	27	(47.4)		39	(43.3)

* Chi-Square goodness of fit

⁺ Fisher's exact test

Table S6. Characteristics of individuals completing the main survey (N=203)

	Completed (N=90)		Not completed (N=113)		p-value*	Total (N=203)	
	N	(%)	N	(%)		N	(%)
Age							
20-24	25	(27.8)	30	(26.5)	0.719	55	(27.1)
25-29	47	(52.2)	55	(48.7)		102	(50.2)
30-35	18	(20.0)	28	(24.8)		46	(22.7)
Gender							
Male	47	(52.2)	59	(52.2)	0.999	106	(52.2)
Female	43	(47.8)	54	(47.8)		97	(47.8)
Ethnicity							
White	52	(57.8)	65	(57.5)	0.661 ⁺	117	(57.6)
Asian	24	(26.7)	24	(21.2)		48	(23.7)
Black	13	(14.4)	21	(18.6)		34	(16.7)
Other	1	(1.1)	3	(2.7)		4	(2.0)
Religion							
Christian	63	(70.0)	83	(73.4)	0.603	146	(71.9)
Non-Christian	10	(11.1)	8	(7.1)		18	(8.9)
No religion	17	(18.9)	22	(19.5)		39	(19.2)
Education							
Bachelor	51	(56.7)	54	(48.8)	0.209	105	(51.7)
Graduate	39	(43.3)	59	(52.2)		98	(48.3)

* Chi-Square goodness of fit

⁺ Fisher's exact test

Questionnaires used in the study

S1 Pilot Study Questionnaire

Collect Email Address

Q1. This questionnaire is to recruit participants. The main questionnaire will be sent via email in one week. Would you like to provide your email address for further study?

- Yes
- No

Q2. What is your mailing address?

Demographic Questions

Q3. What is your year of birth?

Q4. What gender do you identify as?

- Female
- Male
- Other, please specify

Q5. Choose one or more races that you consider yourself to be:

- White
- Black or African American
- American Indian or Alaska Native
- Asian
- Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander
- Other

Q6. What is your current education level?

- Some University but no degree
- University - Bachelors Degree
- Graduate or professional degree (MA, MS, MBA, PhD, Law Degree, Medical Degree etc_
- Prefer not to say

Preference Questions

Q7. When you are invited to fill in a questionnaire, which question type would you prefer to answer?

- Close-ended questions (e.g. multiple choice)
- Open-ended questions (e.g. text entry)
- There is no difference between the two options for me

Q8. If you are invited to fill in a questionnaire, but you need to wait four weeks to receive your participation payment, will you still participate in the study?

- Yes
- I may consider
- No

S2 Control Condition Questionnaire

Demographic Questions

Q1. What is your year of birth?

Q2. What gender do you identify as?

- Female
- Male
- Other, please specify

Q3. Choose one or more races that you consider yourself to be:

- 1.White
- 2.Black or African American
- 3.American Indian or Alaska Native
- 4.Asian
- 5.Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander
- 6.Other

Q4. What is your current education level?

- Some University but no degree
- University - Bachelor Degree
- Graduate or professional degree (MA, MS, MBA, PhD, Law Degree, Medical Degree etc_
- Prefer not to say

Fear of Coronavirus Questionnaire

Q5. Please select the extent to which the following thoughts, feelings and behaviors apply to you: (anchors: 1 = "Strongly disagree"; 5 = "Strongly agree")

	Strongly disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat agree	Strongly agree
1. I am very worried about the corona virus outbreak.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2. I am taking precautions to prevent infection (e.g., washing hands, avoiding contact with people, avoiding door handles).	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3. I am constantly following all news updates regarding the virus.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4. I have stocked up on supplies to prepare for problems related to the coronavirus outbreak.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5. For my personal health I find the virus to be much more dangerous than the seasonal flu.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
6. I feel that the health authorities are not doing enough to deal with the virus.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7. I am worried that friends or family will be infected.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
8. I take more precautions compared to most people to not become infected.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Debrief Questions

Q6. Rank the reasons why you choose to respond to **this survey**.

- I'm interested in this topic.
- I can receive an incentive from completing this survey.
- I can accept the length of the survey.
- I am assured of anonymity.
- I like the question type (closed-ended).

Q7. Rank the reasons why you choose to respond to an online survey.

- Interest in the Topic
- Rewards
- Length of Survey
- Value Privacy (e.g. anonymity)
- The Question Types (closed-ended or open-ended)

S3 Decoy Condition Questionnaire- Target Questionnaire

Demographic Questions

Q1. What is your year of birth?

Q2. What gender do you identify as?

- Female
- Male
- Other, please specify

Q3. Choose one or more races that you consider yourself to be:

- White
- Black or African American
- American Indian or Alaska Native
- Asian
- Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander
- Other

Q4. What is your current education level?

- Some University but no degree
- University - Bachelors Degree
- Graduate or professional degree (MA, MS, MBA, PhD, Law Degree, Medical Degree etc_
- Prefer not to say

Fear of Coronavirus Questionnaire

Q5. Please select the extent to which the following thoughts, feelings and behaviors apply to you: (anchors: 1 = "Strongly disagree"; 5 = "Strongly agree")

	Strongly disagree	Somewhat disagree	Neither agree nor disagree	Somewhat agree	Strongly agree
1. I am very worried about the corona virus outbreak.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2. I am taking precautions to prevent infection (e.g., washing hands, avoiding contact with people, avoiding door handles).	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3. I am constantly following all news updates regarding the virus.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4. I have stocked up on supplies to prepare for problems related to the coronavirus outbreak.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5. For my personal health I find the virus to be much more dangerous than the seasonal flu.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
6. I feel that the health authorities are not doing enough to deal with the virus.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7. I am worried that friends or family will be infected.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
8. I take more precautions compared to most people to not become infected.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Debrief Questions

Q6. Why did you choose to answer the closed-ended questions instead of the open-ended questions?

- Closed-ended questions take me less time.
- The payment of this type questionnaire is faster.
- Both of them.
- Neither of them. (please write your reason)

Q7. Rank the reasons why you choose to respond to **this survey**.

- I'm interested in this topic.
- I can receive an incentive from completing this survey.
- I can accept the length of the survey.
- I am assured of anonymity.
- I like the question type (closed-ended).

Q8. Rank the reasons why you choose to respond to an online survey.

- Interest in the Topic
- Rewards
- Length of Survey
- Value Privacy (e.g. anonymity)

- The Question Types (closed-ended or open-ended)

Q9. Being offered an inferior choice (like the open question and late payment in this case) can stimulate me to respond to a survey.

- Strongly agree
- Somewhat agree
- Disagree
- Somewhat disagree
- Strongly disagree

S4 Decoy Condition Questionnaire- Decoy Questionnaire

Demographic Questions

Q1. What is your year of birth?

Q2. What gender do you identify as?

- Female
- Male
- Other, please specify

Q3. Choose one or more races that you consider yourself to be:

- White
- Black or African American
- American Indian or Alaska Native
- Asian
- Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander
- Other

Q4. What is your current education level?

- Some University but no degree
- University - Bachelors Degree
- Graduate or professional degree (MA, MS, MBA, PhD, Law Degree, Medical Degree etc_
- Prefer not to say

Open-ended Questions

Q5. Can you describe how your attitude towards coronavirus has changed from the beginning until now? (no less than 100 words)

Q6. Can you describe what precautions you know to prevent infection? Which ones have you done? Do you continue doing them ? (no less than 100 words)

Debrief Questions

Q7. Why did you choose to answer the open-ended questions instead of the closed-ended questions? (no less than five words)

Q8. Rank the reasons why you choose to respond to this survey.

- I'm interested in this topic.
- I can receive an incentive from completing this survey.
- I can accept the length of the survey.
- I am assured of anonymity.
- I like the question type (open-ended).

Q9. Rank the reasons why you choose to respond to an online survey.

- Interest in the Topic
- Rewards
- Length of Survey
- Value Privacy (e.g. anonymity)
- The Question Types (closed-ended or open-ended)

Q10. Open-ended questions are more appealing to me than the closed-ended questions.

- Strongly agree
- Somewhat agree
- Disagree
- Somewhat disagree
- Strongly disagree

Q11. Late payment of incentives is more appealing to me than immediate payment.

- Strongly agree
- Somewhat agree
- Disagree
- Somewhat disagree
- Strongly disagree